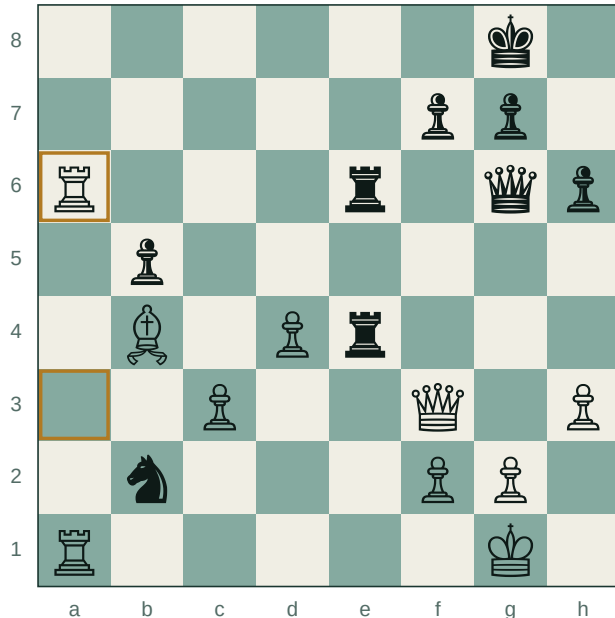


Intermediate moves: Black, move 31

Intermediate moves

Black to move



Previous move: 31.Rxa6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

31...Rxa6 32. Rxa6 Re1+ 33. Kh2 Qxa6

31...Rxa6 The rook captures the rook on a6. Recorded reply: **32.Rxa6**.

32...Re1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **33.Kh2**.

33...Qxa6 The queen captures the rook on a6.

At the end, nominal material is White 17 / Black 21 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from -1 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g1. Absolute pin: pawn on g2.